Sun's apparent movement against the background of the constellations of fixed stars, as discussed above. The frame of reference for the tropical zodiac is the seasonal path of the Sun relative to the Earth.

As the Sun travels north and south of the equator during its annual journey, its yearly course is marked by four critical turning points, known as the solstices and equinoxes. Each of these turning points initiates one of the four seasons.

At the Winter Solstice, the Sun reaches its southernmost declination, where daytime hours are shortest. It then moves in a northerly direction and the light hours begin to increase. At the Spring Equinox, the Sun crosses the celestial equator where day and night hours are equal. It reaches its northernmost declination at the Summer Solstice, the longest day of the year. It then turns south and crosses the celestial equator again at the Fall Equinox, equalizing day and night. Now the night continues to increase until the Sun reaches the Winter Solstice again.

This path of the Sun is divided into twelve equal thirty-degree segments of zodiacal signs. The beginning of the seasons—Spring, Summer, Fall, and Winter, as marked by the equinoxes and solstices—correspond to the first degree of Aries, Cancer, Libra, and Capricorn, respectively. The equal divisions of the remaining signs complete the zodiacal circle.

Astronomers, Hindu Vedic astrologers, and some "western sidereal" astrologers use the sidereal zodiac, while most western astrologers use the tropical zodiac in order to denote the location of the planets. This has generated tremendous confusion among both astrologers and the non-astrological public, resulting in a host of controversies due to the use of the same term to designate different frames of reference.

These two different zodiacal locational systems were not much of a problem when Hellenistic astrology was first being formulated in the early centuries of our era. At that time, the zodiacal constellations were roughly aligned with the seasonal zodiacal signs (see FIGURE 14). Looking out from Earth, the Spring Equinox point at 0° Aries was approximately in the same line of vision as the beginning of the constellation Aries. Valens and others noted that in their era the Spring Equinox point was at 8° Aries.[1] However, this is now much more of a problem because the two zodiacs have separated over the intervening time by about 24° (see FIGURE 15). This is due to the astronomical phenomenon of precession.

1 VALENS, *Anthology* 9.12P, trans. RILEY.